

Alicante: walk up to the castle

Tuesday 22 September 2026 | 16:00 – 20:15 | on foot

From the Teatro Principal to the Castillo de Santa Bárbara, through the old town and the Ereta park

An afternoon walk from the centre of Alicante up to the Castillo de Santa Bárbara. We climb through the old town and the gardens of La Ereta to the fortress that has stood above the bay for more than a thousand years.

THE ROUTE, STOP BY STOP

16:00 Teatro Principal

PLAZA RUPERTO CHAPÍ

The city's main theatre opened in 1847, at a time when Alicante was growing rich on Mediterranean trade and spreading beyond its old walls. Six columns and a triangular pediment front a horseshoe-shaped auditorium. It was built to show what the city had become, and it has been at the centre of public life here ever since. The square is named after Ruperto Chapí, a composer born in Villena, in this province, whose zarzuelas were played all over Spain.

16:20 Plaza del Ayuntamiento

THE TOWN HALL

The town hall took most of the 18th century to build, and its baroque front stands between two towers. Inside, on the first step of the main staircase, is the *cota cero*: the point from which every height in Spain is measured. It is here because a tide gauge in the port of Alicante was used to define mean sea level for the whole country. Every mountain height on a Spanish map is counted from this doorstep.

16:25 Concatedral de San Nicolás

PLAZA DEL ABAD PENALVA

Built between 1616 and 1662, the co-cathedral is deliberately plain: bare stone, straight lines, almost no decoration, under a dome that rises about 45 metres above the old town. The architect had trained under the man who built El Escorial, and it shows. There is one exception. The Communion Chapel beside the nave is covered in gold and colour, and the change is a surprise. The cloister next to it is older still, left over from the smaller church that stood here before.

16:30 Plaza de la Santísima Faz

COFFEE STOP

A small square of palm trees and terraces behind the town hall. It is named after the Santa Faz, a cloth said to carry the imprint of Christ's face, which was brought to Alicante in the 15th century and is kept in a monastery about six kilometres outside the city. Every spring, on the second Thursday after Easter, hundreds of thousands of people walk out to it carrying stalks of rosemary. It is the biggest pilgrimage in Spain after El Rocío, and the oldest tradition the city has.

16:40 **Basílica de Santa María**

FIRST REGROUPING POINT

The oldest church in Alicante. It was begun in the 14th century on the site of the main mosque and worked on for two hundred years, which is why its single Gothic nave feels plainer than everything around it. In the 18th century a richly carved baroque doorway was added to that severe front, with a Virgin surrounded by swirling stone. The two styles side by side are the short version of the city's architecture. Across the square is the MACA, Alicante's museum of contemporary art, which is free.

16:50 **Ermita de Santa Cruz**

BARRIO DE SANTA CRUZ

The old quarter climbs the hillside in whitewashed houses and stepped lanes too narrow for a car. It grew up under the castle walls and still feels separate from the rest of the city. There are pots of geraniums on every wall, and at the end of April the neighbourhood covers its crosses in flowers for its own small festival. At the top of the barrio stands the little hermitage of Santa Cruz, where the lanes end and the rooftops drop away towards the sea.

17:00 **Parque de la Ereta**

SECOND REGROUPING POINT

Terraces cut into the side of Mount Benacantil and planted with olives, pines and other Mediterranean trees. The park opened in 2003 and links the old town to the fortress above, on a slope that had been left derelict for years. Its name comes from *ereta*, a small walled plot built in steps on a hillside, which is exactly what the place is. The path climbs to a series of balconies with the whole city below: the grid of the Ensanche, the port, the beaches and the mountains inland.

17:10 **Castillo de Santa Bárbara**

FREE ENTRY, UNTIL 20:00

One of the largest medieval fortresses in Spain, built by the Moors in the late 9th century on a rock that watches the entire bay. It was taken by Castile on 4 December 1248 by the future king Alfonso X, on the feast day of Saint Barbara, and it has carried her name since. Philip II rebuilt it between 1562 and 1580 as a modern artillery fortress, and that is more or less its shape today, spread over three levels from three different periods. A French fleet bombarded it in 1691. Later it became a prison. It was left empty for many years and opened to the public in 1963, when lifts were cut up through the rock from the seafront.

19:40 **Descent and sunset**

PARQUE DE LA ERETA

The fortress closes at eight. Below it, the terraces of La Ereta face west over the bay, and the last light catches the castle walls above and the roofs of the barrio below at the same time. From the right spot on the way down, the south face of Benacantil turns into a human profile: the Cara del Moro, the Moor's Face, which the city has told stories about for centuries.

PRACTICAL NOTES

Cost	Nothing. The castle, the museum and the walk are all free; we go up on foot, not by the paid lift.
The walk	About 2 km, climbing some 150 m, roughly an hour at an easy pace. Parts of the old quarter and the park are stairs.
Bring	Comfortable closed shoes, water, sun protection.
If you get lost	Pin Plaza de la Ereta on your phone rather than the castle.
Timings	Last entry on foot is 19:30 and the gates close at 20:00, so please keep to the departure times.